

Mozart's 'Idomeneo'

by Hans Gal

It is undeniable that Mozart's full stature as a dramatic composer has only been realized in our century. Today, it sounds like a truism to call him the greatest of all operatic composers, but this recognition is amazingly recent. No reasonable person would expect a great composer's contemporaries to be fully conscious of his importance. When Mozart's most distinguished patron, the Emperor Joseph, condescendingly called him "*un talent decide*"—he obviously preferred Piccinni or Cimarosa—his attitude was probably in no way different from most of his educated, music-loving contemporaries. But still, during most of the nineteenth century Mozart's operas played a comparatively modest part on the operatic stage. Rarely performed in France, hardly ever in Italy, they occupied even in Germany a position of somewhat aristocratic isolation loved by the few, little appreciated by the vast majority, overshadowed by the pompous vulgarity of grand opera, and later by the thick, heavy clouds of Wagnerism. Three of them, however, maintained themselves, or were at least revived over and over again : *Le Nozze di Figaro*, *Don Giovanni* and *The Magic Flute*. *Il Seraglio* was occasionally tried, and usually with success. *Così fan Tutte*, on the other hand, was neglected; its libretto was regarded as absurd and morally objectionable, and it has only found its proper place in the repertory during the last thirty years or so.

Has the time come now for the recovery of *Idomeneo*? A considerable number of isolated appearances of this work indicates at least an increasing interest in it during the last few years. But for the public in general, even for the serious lover of music, this long neglected opera is still *terra incognita* and seems to suggest a forbidding atmosphere of dust, mould and remoteness.

Idomeneo occupies a peculiar position in Mozart's development: it was his first great work. It is an error to regard Mozart, the composer, as an infant prodigy in more than a technical sense. There are occasional flashes of genius in his earlier work, but most of it is hardly superior to the conventional average of his time, and his own individuality as a composer rarely asserts itself in works written before he was eighteen. When he was commissioned to write *Idomeneo* for Munich, in 1780, he was twenty-four, fully mature and prepared to do something extraordinary. This work has the unique, incomparable charm one finds in a first full revelation of a personality, of a great artist realizing for the first time his unlimited range and power of invention and expression. *Idomeneo* is bursting with music, with vitality, with a sensuous delight in vocal and orchestral beauty. And, this precious score reveals on every page that it was written for what at that time was the best orchestra in the world, the famous Mannheim Court Chapel which, together with the Palatinal Court, had moved to Munich shortly before.

The problem of this opera, however, is, how to make it convincing on the stage, and this problem is *rooted* in the style and structure of the libretto. It is easy enough to see the weak side of the dramatic plot. But this weakness is, so to speak, not peculiar to this individual opera; it is inherent in the constitution of the baroque *opera seria*, of which this is a late offspring at a time when the whole species had already become obsolete, superseded both by Gluck's new, noble type of dramatic opera and by the realistic freshness and lightness of *opera buffa*, which latter form Mozart was destined to lead to its highest pinnacle. As a traditional type of opera, *Idomeneo* was then outdated when it was first produced on the stage. Fortunately, the history of music is not merely a chronicle of rising and declining species, but of great individuals: as an individual, *Idomeneo* is an immortal work.

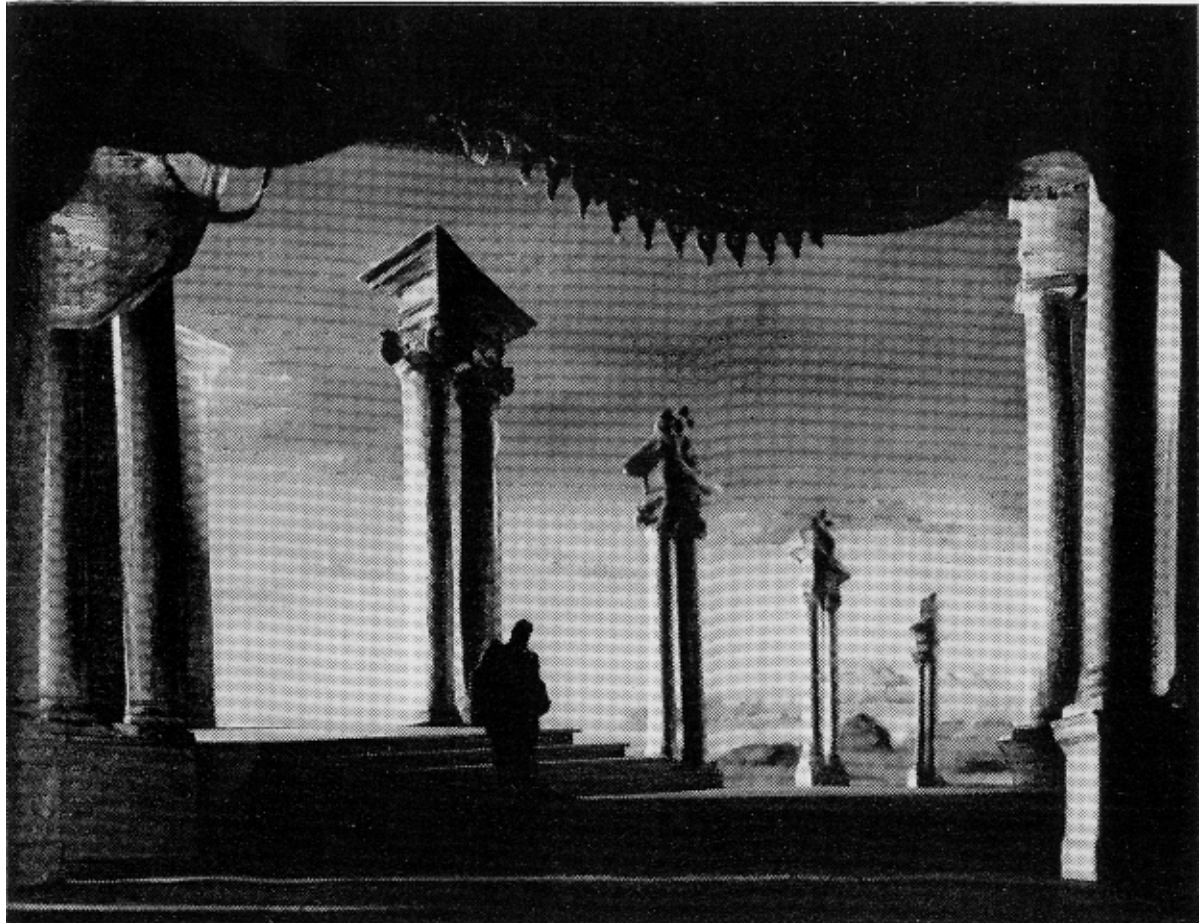
In its dramatic style and construction, it is a characteristic specimen of baroque opera, based on a mixture of Italian and French baroque-classical tradition. In this connection, one naturally thinks of Gluck, whose whole work grew from the same roots. Indeed, it has often

been remarked that *Idomeneo* shows Gluck's influence, and I confess I held the same view until recently when, working at a practical edition for the forthcoming performance in Glyndebourne, I became passionately interested in, and absorbed by, *Idomeneo*. The truth is that the more one becomes acquainted with Mozart's work, the more one realizes how remote his world is from Gluck's and how superficial Mozart's relation to Gluck remained in all the essential features of his dramatic style. He must have known Gluck's music—he heard *Iphigenia en Aulide*, *Alceste*, *Orfeo*, *Armide* in Paris in 1778—and although the only references to Gluck in his letters are quite impersonal, it is likely that the young composer was impressed by the lofty nobility of those works and by the tremendous prestige Gluck, at the height of his fame and success, had at that time. The fact is that Abbate Giambattista Varesco, court chaplain in Salzburg, who wrote the libretto of *Idomeneo*, used a French source for it, a libretto by Dauchet, which had already been set to music by Campra and performed in Paris in 1712 and that the French style of this source quite naturally influenced Varesco's work and, as a result, Mozart's. Another obvious influence on the writer of the libretto is Metastasio, the greatest librettist of Italian opera seria and incidentally the main butt of Gluck's most ferocious diatribes against the misuses and rooted evils in opera. The libretto of *Idomeneo* is pure Metastasio, with some characteristic elements of French pre-Gluckian opera. Whoever knows Gluck's *Alceste* will be reminded of it when in the last act of *Idomeneo* the subterranean voice of Poseidon miraculously solves the conflict. But this is no more Gluck's than Mozart's invention; it is an old device of the baroque theatre, the classical *deus ex machina*, just as the dramatic choral scenes and ballet scenes which frequently appear in Gluck's works belong to the main pattern of French baroque opera and from there found their way into Varesco's libretto. Mozart may have been consciously or subconsciously influenced by the impression of some scenes of Gluck's—most of all in *Alceste*—when he conceived the terrific choral scenes in *Idomeneo*. But he shows himself as blissfully ignorant of Gluck's ideas in the composition of the music, as Abbate Varesco was when he wrote a libretto, the whole construction of which, as well as the place it assigns to arias and ensembles and their actual wording, sorely offends Gluck's most emphatically pronounced principles. Gluck's plots are based on dramatically active, individually shaped characters; Varesco's characters, like Metastasio's, are just puppets in the hands of a preordained fate. For Gluck, the aria is integrated in the dramatic situation and a part of it; for Varesco, or Metastasio, it is, from the dramatical point of view, a place of lyrical contemplation, and, from the musical, an occasion for the display of vocal virtuosity, the main aim and end of opera.

And Mozart? Well, he was gloriously unprincipled, just as Gluck was obstinately dogmatic, an unconditional idealist, obsessed with his idea of a musical drama. Mozart, as a naïve realist, was determined to take the utmost advantage of all musical possibilities at his disposal, including vocal virtuosity which Gluck despised so much. Born with an uncanny dramatic vitality and intensity of feeling, experienced in opera through a dozen works written for the stage as a child and an adolescent, Mozart had the tremendous self-confidence of a musician who knows that he can find the right musical atmosphere for any given dramatic situation, and of a dramatist who knows that, however extravagantly his music may expand, the dramatic momentum and consistency will never be endangered. He was ready to conform to any type of operatic tradition without any sacrifice of principles or conscience, because it did not affect the essential action of his genius.

In the case of *Idomeneo*, the type of opera to which Mozart had to conform was constitutionally static, not dramatic. This explains those sections which may appear dramatically weak to the modern audience. Quite a number of attempts have been made to improve upon this imputed defect, the most notable of which is by Richard Strauss, who added a good deal of music of his own, including an elaborate ensemble-finale. But it is, to say the least of it, questionable whether there is any point in trying to improve upon a masterpiece by

applying to it principles foreign to its nature. *Idomeneo* represents a pre-Gluckian type of opera, but contains some of Mozart's most fascinating music; everywhere is apparent his own incomparable faculty for expressing the passions and emotions of characters that become altogether human, pathetic and convincing through this art. Admittedly, there is an abundance of purely episodic, lyrical arias. But they are not merely beautiful music; as if unintentionally, they transform the respective characters into living, suffering, exultant human beings; and there are just sufficient scenes of true dramatic power—some of the grandest even Mozart has written— to provide the necessary counterbalance.



Oliver Messel's design for Act I Scene 3 of 'Idomeneo' at Glyndebourne this year.

Photo Angus McBean

After these explanations it will be understood that the Glyndebourne version keeps faithfully to Mozart's score. But it takes full advantage of a later version, made for a private performance in Vienna in 1786, at the time of *Figaro*, which contains generous cuts, some precious new pieces, and Mozart's own solution of a problem which has puzzled all editors : how to replace a male soprano, a castrato, for whom the part of Idamante was originally written. This part which Richard Strauss and Vittorio Gui (in a recent edition have assigned to a female soprano, is unsuitable for this voice, not only on dramatic grounds—Idamante is not a youngster like Cherubino but a man and a hero—but also for musical reasons. We know from many contemporary descriptions that the castrato voice sounded strikingly different from the female voice, much more strident and metallic. Another female soprano, added to the two of the original, would result in a noticeable lack of variety in a work with such an abundance of

arias. In his Vienna version, Mozart gave the part of Idamante to a tenor, taking the trouble to rearrange the ensembles according to the changed musical situation. He also gave a lead in cutting out the two arias of Arbace, who represents a "confidant," a person whose function is merely to act as a partner in dialogue with one of the protagonists, in order to get over the necessary explanations or exposition of facts. In opera, this old expedient becomes a liability, if the "confidant" has to get his due share of arias, which necessarily are dramatically redundant. Mozart must have felt this weakness, and his two arias, the most conventional of the opera, can easily be omitted.

Can Idomeneo be a success? I think it can, with a sensitive, educated audience. A performance of a work like this is bound to be an experiment, and we are indebted to Glyndebourne for trying it. And after all, opera, the most extravagant luxury amongst musical institutions, justifies its existence only if it is capable of maintaining alive, say, three dozen of the most accomplished masterpieces of its kind. Idomeneo, to the best of my belief, is one of them. It is time to bring it out of cold storage.

[From: *Opera* 2/8, 1951.]